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Can nature sell beauty? Historicising cosmetic advertising and its modern greenwashing parallels

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to investigate how late 19th- and early 20th-century cosmetic advertisements used natural ingredients to enhance product appeal. This study examines the visual rhetoric and semiotic strategies that symbolised naturalness and sustainability during this period, as well as the ethical implications of these marketing practices, particularly regarding consumer deception and their connection to modern greenwashing.

Design/methodology/approach – Using a qualitative approach, this study applies multimodal critical discourse analysis, integrating visual rhetoric, semiotic analysis and historical contextualisation. A data set of 118 vintage cosmetic advertisements from archives is analysed to identify key themes.

Findings – The findings of this study reveal that advertisers romanticised natural ingredients by depicting idyllic nature scenes and associating products with purity, health and beauty. Visual and linguistic strategies were used to create a dual appeal of nature and science, enhancing consumer trust. However, these practices often mask the realities of production processes and ingredient authenticity, leading to potential consumer deception.

Research limitations/implications – This study focuses on a specific data set of historical advertisements, limiting generalisability across industries. Future research could expand to other sectors or regions.

Originality/value – This research contributes to understanding the historical roots of greenwashing, offering a transhistorical perspective on the use of nature in advertising. This study highlights the ongoing ethical challenges related to consumer manipulation through deceptive environmental claims.

Keywords Greenwashing, Ethical marketing, Multimodal critical discourse analysis, Consumer deception, Cosmetic advertising, Natural ingredients

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

In an 1880s edition of The Graphic, a British weekly illustrated newspaper, an advertisement for Pears' Soap captivated readers with a serene countryside scene: a woman washing her face with crystal-clear brook water, enveloped by vibrant greenery and blossoming flowers (The Graphic, 1884). This idyllic image was not about just selling soap; it was selling an association with nature's purity and the promise of health and beauty derived from the natural world. Such advertisements were not isolated incidents but part of a broader trend in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, where cosmetic companies increasingly harnessed the allure of natural ingredients to captivate consumers. The 20th century saw rapid

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industrialisation and urbanisation, causing public anxiety about the loss of connection with nature and potential health implications of modern living (Angelo, 2020). In response, cosmetic advertisers began to emphasise natural components in their products, using visual and linguistic strategies that romanticised nature and suggested that beauty and, by extension, femininity could be enhanced through natural means.

Greenwashing, the act of exaggerating or fabricating a product's environmental or "natural" advantages, has been extensively studied in recent academic works, with a focus on its use in contemporary marketing (Riccolo, 2021a, 2021b). However, comparatively little attention has been paid to its historical precursors and the ways in which advertisers first harnessed romanticised images of nature to shape consumer perceptions. Marketing historians have mapped how industrialisation and shifting cultural norms influenced consumption patterns (Fine and Leopold, 1990), yet they have seldom explored how nature-based rhetoric in late 19th- and early 20th-century cosmetic advertisements set the stage for current ethical controversies. Although we know that nature has long been commercialised as a marker of purity and health (Chaachouay and Zidane, 2024; Lauwers *et al.*, 2020), empirical studies rarely investigate the precise visual and linguistic strategies that advertisers used in this formative era and how these strategies may serve as prototypes for modern greenwashing.

While the promotion of natural ingredients may appear harmless at first glance, these marketing strategies have played a significant role in the commodification of nature, turning aspects of the natural environment into items for commercial exchange. The symbolism associated with natural ingredients in the marketing of beauty products goes beyond simple aesthetic appeal; it resonates with consumers' aspirations for health, well-being and a sense of moral integrity linked to the concept of natural purity. While the glamorisation of nature is enticing, it obscures the true realities of production processes and the authenticity of the ingredients involved, raising significant ethical concerns about consumer deception.

To critically examine how these advertising discourses were constructed and how they continue to inform contemporary greenwashing narratives, this study uses multimodal critical discourse analysis (MCDA). MCDA is particularly suited for analysing advertisements as multimodal texts that integrate visual imagery, textual copy and design elements to convey layered meanings (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2020; Machin and Mayr, 2012). By applying MCDA, this research interrogates not only the surface content of historical cosmetic advertisements but also the underlying ideologies and power structures embedded in the representations of nature, purity and femininity. This method allows for a critical exploration of how visual and textual strategies worked together to naturalise moralised consumption narratives, a practice that persists in modern sustainability marketing.

A growing number of works explore how companies today claim "sustainability" or "organic" ingredients to secure consumer trust (Chkanikova and Lehner, 2014; Nuttavuthisit and Thøgersen, 2015; Wang and Jung, 2025). These studies illuminate how consumers interpret and respond to green or natural imagery in advertising campaigns, revealing current regulatory and ethical tensions around misleading claims. Yet few scholars systematically investigate where these rhetorical practices originated, namely, in the advertising boom of the late Victorian and early Edwardian eras. The significance of placing marketing strategies within a historical framework has been emphasised, with a call for research spanning both historical and modern contexts to uncover enduring patterns of consumer influence (O'Hagan, 2022). Despite others' efforts, a persistent gap remains: the absence of detailed analysis of how romanticised or mythic representations of nature, deployed over a century ago, directly inform or foreshadow the modern-day phenomenon of greenwashing.

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As a result, the transhistorical continuity between the late 19th century's commodification of nature and today's ethical dilemmas around deceptive "green" claims is underexplored.

This research aims to address this gap by doing a historical and visual rhetoric analysis of cosmetic advertisements from the late 19th and early 20th centuries. This research aims to address this gap by utilizing a dataset of 118 advertisements, primarily gathered from diverse web archives. It considers the following research questions:

Q1. How did late 19th- and early 20th-century cosmetic advertisements use natural ingredients to enhance product appeal, and what historical factors influenced this practice?

Q2. What visual rhetoric and semiotic strategies did advertisers use to symbolise naturalness and sustainability in cosmetic products during this period?

Q3. What are the ethical implications of these historical marketing practices, particularly regarding the potential for consumer deception?

Q4. In what ways do the marketing strategies of the late 19th and early 20th centuries connect to modern practices of greenwashing in the cosmetics industry, and what continuities or changes are evident?

Addressing these research questions and gaps has significant implications for marketing history, consumer research and ethical considerations. From a historical perspective, examining advertising archives reveals the origins of nature-based marketing claims and how industrialisation and societal shifts shaped associations between nature, purity and beauty. Additionally, insights drawn from historical advertisements can significantly inform contemporary consumer research. Highlighting how early cosmetic ads constructed and reinforced notions of purity, moral integrity and authenticity deepens the understanding of how these appeals continue to shape modern consumer attitudes, purchase decisions and perceived trustworthiness. Furthermore, examining these historical examples contextualises today's ethical debates on greenwashing, demonstrating that misleading environmental claims are not new but have long been a strategy in marketing. Recognising this continuity can help stakeholders develop more effective regulatory frameworks and ethical guidelines, allowing them to address deceptive claims and protect consumer rights more proactively.

A historical lens is essential for tracing the emergence, traction and evolution of enduring marketing tropes. Visual rhetoric enables the analysis of text and image interplay in vintage advertising, elements crucial for forging emotional and aspirational consumer connections. Deconstructing imagery such as idyllic pastoral scenes, scientific "miracles" and depictions of gendered purity illustrates how advertisers both reflected and shaped societal values, anticipating strategies replicated in modern marketing discourse (Fairclough, 2013a, 2013b). This research aims to demonstrate that what is now classified, as greenwashing is not a new tactic but a continuation of longstanding marketing practices designed to obscure the truth about production processes and product content.

Literature review

From enlightenment rationalism to romantic ideals of nature

The Enlightenment era is often associated with an emphasis on scientific progress, rational inquiry and human mastery over the environment. This worldview is reflected in the "technological determinism" debates that position technology and scientific rationality as prime drivers of societal change (Wengenroth *et al.*, 1998). In the wake of these developments, humans increasingly perceived nature as a resource to be dissected, measured and exploited for human gain. During this period, the Earth's ecosystems were gradually stripped of their spiritual

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or intrinsic value, a process referred to as the "death of nature" (Merchant, 1998). The modern perspective on nature is largely economic or instrumental, a product of the merging of Enlightenment mechanistic thinking with heightened industrial interests.

On the other hand, Romanticism arose as a literary and cultural movement in opposition to the Enlightenment's rationalist ideology during the late 18th and early 19th centuries, when the Industrial Revolution was gathering steam. Romanticism is described as a collective reaction against the domination of mechanistic science, wherein poets and philosophers reclaimed the emotional and subjective experience of the natural world (Fosso and Oerlemans, 2005). By doing so, they challenged purely instrumental views of nature and explored themes such as the sublime, pastoral nostalgia and humanity's spiritual bond with the environment. This Romantic resurgence had a lasting impact on Western cultural values, which became evident in popular discourse, literature and early advertising imagery that glorified landscapes and rustic settings (Williams, 2022).

In The Country and the City, cultural representations of "rural simplicity" are portrayed as idealised responses to the chaos and pollution of growing metropolises (Williams, 1975). Particularly in societies experiencing fast technological change, these perfect images sometimes reflected a yearning for spiritual renewal or moral purity. Similarly, Leo Marx's The Machine in the Garden explores how the interplay between technological progress (the "machine") and the pastoral landscape (the "garden") influenced the American imagination. Through literary and cultural narratives, romanticised depictions of nature were used to evoke nostalgia for a disappearing agrarian ideal, framing nature as a source of longing, redemption and moral virtue (Marx, 1964). This Romantic resurgence not only shaped literary and artistic expressions but also influenced broader cultural narratives that positioned nature as a refuge from industrial modernity. As urban-industrial modernity intensified anxieties about alienation and artificiality, representations of unspoiled nature gained economic and symbolic power. These frameworks clarify why advertisers especially in emergent consumer economies would capitalise on such deep-seated cultural narratives. By placing a product in a seemingly arcadian setting, they could evoke emotional resonance and trust, appealing to the Romantic notion that genuine or moral value resided in nature rather than in machines or factories.

It is important to note that romanticised nature imagery was never confined to a single cultural context. As multinational brands emerged, similar strategies took shape in colonial and postcolonial settings, where references to "traditional" herbal remedies or "untouched" landscapes played into existing cultural beliefs (McMullen and Dell'Acqua, 2023). Advertisements across Asia, for instance, capitalised on longstanding traditions of holistic medicine, promising that products harnessed the secrets of Ayurveda, Traditional Chinese Medicine or local indigenous knowledges (Patwardhan *et al.*, 2005). Meanwhile, Western companies marketing in colonial contexts often romanticised resource-rich locales such as plantations or spice routes while glossing over exploitative labour practices or environmental degradation. In all these settings, the symbolic power of nature remained central. Whether referencing lavender fields of provincial France, the meadows of rural England or the spice plantations of colonial India, advertisements consistently merged the exotic with the pastoral. They effectively sold not just the product, but the emotional experience of reconnecting with a simpler, purer world an aspiration that transcended national boundaries. Such imagery laid a universal foundation for subsequent marketing narratives that still remain globally persuasive today (O'Hagan, 2021).

The commodification of nature inevitably brought tensions between the presumed "purity" of a product and its complex supply chains. For instance, a soap manufacturer could tout an advertisement featuring pristine waterfalls while sourcing cheap tallow from

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industrial meat-processing plants (Russell *et al.*, 2024). This tension has always been at the heart of consumer deception: the brand narrative might highlight a single botanical extract, underplaying or ignoring the dozens of synthetic or industrially derived components also present in the formula. Over the past century, the dissonance between "pure" imagery and actual manufacturing processes has often escalated into concerns over transparency, authenticity and ethical accountability themes that resonate strongly in contemporary discussions of greenwashing (Alyahia *et al.*, 2024; Dempere *et al.*, 2024; Free *et al.*, 2024; Marrucci *et al.*, 2025).

The feminisation of nature

In The Death of Nature, Western thought underwent a profound shift during the Scientific Revolution, redefining the Earth from a nurturing maternal figure to a mechanistic resource open to exploitation (Merchant, 1998). This conceptual "feminization of nature" not only permitted the literal exploitation of the environment but also reshaped cultural perceptions, depicting the natural world as a passive female entity to be tamed or harnessed for profit. In the late 19th and early 20th centuries, marketers cleverly connected cosmetic products to the nurturing qualities of motherhood and the gentleness of nature. This approach tapped into a cultural understanding that viewed the environment as a source of comfort and support, while also suggesting that women, much like nature, were meant to fulfil roles that served social or domestic purposes. Historical beauty advertisements often showcased delicate, vulnerable feminine figures, subtly emphasising the notion that both women and the natural world needed care, support or enhancement through commercial products. The Merchant's framework sheds light on why many early advertisements for cosmetics framed them as tools for preserving or enhancing "naturally" feminine traits. During a time when science was becoming more influential, linking these products to the comforting ideals of a maternal environment helped protect them from scepticism.

Linking Merchant's argument to historical cosmetic advertising, there are numerous examples of promotional copy and visuals that depict the environment as a maternal or benevolent force that passively yields its gifts for the benefit of women. Ads for soap or lotion in the early 20th century frequently featured images of gentle streams, blossoms or harvestable fields, all of which were coded as nurturing and docile. Marketers maintained the sense of nature's "feminine warmth" while positioning the advertised product as the savvy scientific mediator, an agent that harnessed nature's goodness for "proper" use (Heflick *et al.*, 2010). The structure of these ads made it clear that while nature was benevolent, it was also incomplete without industrial refinement or packaging. This is consistent with Merchant's ecofeminist critique: the environment is culturally assigned female status (sensitive, mild and generative) but is deemed powerless to realise its own potential unless subjected to human often male coded expertise (Merchant, 1998).

This marketing logic mirrored the broader shift in household economics, in which women became the primary purchasers of domestic goods, including cosmetics (Roberts, 1998). The maternal coding of nature reassured these female consumers that they were fulfilling a moral or nurturing function by selecting products that tapped into Earth's "organic" qualities. At the same time, manufacturers infused their promotions with scientific or technological cues, subtly claiming that the raw resources of nature needed industrial "perfection" to be truly beneficial. In line with Merchant's thesis, this dual narrative of "feminine nature/paternal science" rationalised not only the exploitation of resources but also the cultural assumption that women should manage the home through conscientious (but effectively consumerist) engagement with nature's bounty. The connection between woman-as-nurturer and nature-as-resource explains why nature-themed cosmetic marketing remains so influential today.

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Greenwashing and ethical debates

Though the term "greenwashing" became popular in the late 20th century, environmental marketing claims have earlier precedents. Research shows that as early as the 19th century, advertisers exploited consumers' environmental concerns albeit framed them as anxieties about pollution, disease and adulteration (Hagan, 2021). References to "eco-friendliness" in that era might be subtle, typically surfacing as phrases like "free from harmful chemicals" or "gentle on the land". The deeper pattern, however, is recognisable: product language that suggests alignment with nature's cycles, minimal environmental disruption or moral superiority through "clean" production methods. In modern times, these strategies have metastasised into a more defined phenomenon "greenwashing" in which companies exaggerate or fabricate environmental benefits to capitalise on the consumer's ethical or ecological values (De Freitas Netto *et al.*, 2020). Although the concept that companies might overstate their environmental credentials is not new, the rise of environmentally conscious consumers has made such strategies especially obvious. When people are willing to buy into sustainable practices but do not have the knowledge or resources to independently confirm each claim, greenwashing flourishes.

Greenwashing tactics have been classified using a variety of taxonomies proposed by researchers and consumer advocates. For example, the early forms were known as the "Seven Sins of Greenwashing," which ranged from "Sin of the Hidden Trade-off" to "Sin of No Proof" (Terrachoice, 2010). Another typology differentiates between several levels of false green promises (Seele and Gatti, 2015). In a similar line, a different investigation examined how greenwashing can range from minor exaggeration to serious deception (Lyon and Montgomery, 2015). Contemporary examples often revolve around packaging claims or selective disclosure (Delmas and Burbano, 2011). Yet the underlying rhetorical formula highlight a few seemingly "natural" features while obscuring the broader industrial or ecological footprint can be traced back to many of the historical practices described earlier (Murdoch and Miele, 1999b; Ottman, 2011). Greenwashing occurs for many reasons in business, but the majority of them have to do with gaining an advantage in the marketplace. Despite the idealistic portrayal of nature in advertising, the behind-the-scenes reality can be industrial, polluting or exploitative. This disconnect between the idyllic environment in marketing and the tangible harm inflicted on ecosystems constitutes a prime context for greenwashing.

Ethical debates around greenwashing hinge on issues of consumer deception, corporate social responsibility and market regulation (Forliano *et al.*, 2025). Research found that illusions of nature, if only partially accurate, can still drive positive consumer engagement with sustainability (Santa and Drews, 2023). Other studies highlight the risks: repeated exposure to half-truths erodes trust, dilutes meaningful eco-labels and fosters complacency about genuine environmental risks (Dutta-Powell *et al.*, 2023; Rahman *et al.*, 2015; Walker and Wan, 2011). Thus, contemporary greenwashing controversies are part of a deeper pattern of how capitalism and industrial advertising harness the moral authority of "nature" while disregarding the real socio-environmental impacts.

A central question that emerges is whether any ad using nature-based imagery or language is automatically greenwashing. According to the majority of research, not all references to nature are misleading. Indeed, many companies do maintain ecologically responsible practices and use genuine plant-based ingredients. Research points out that romantic references to nature are deeply embedded in cultural expression, not solely a marketing device (Canniford and Shankar, 2012). Thus, referencing forests or gardens, in itself, need not be unethical or misleading. Greenwashing, on the other hand, results from the intention or effect of using nature-based appeals being to skew consumer views on the whole environmental impact of the product. In this context, an advertisement does not need

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to make outright false claims to engage in greenwashing strategic visual and linguistic cues alone can create misleading impressions.

Methodology and data

Data sampling and archival sources

This research is grounded in a collection of 118 cosmetic advertisements that span the years from 1880 to 1970. The advertisements by manual means were meticulously gathered through a comprehensive search across a diverse range of web archives and historical collections. This includes esteemed sources such as the Duke University Libraries Digital Collections, the British Library Newspaper Archive, the Library of Congress Digital Collections and the National Archives (the UK), as well as notable historical newspapers and magazines like *The Graphic*, *Harper's Bazaar*, *The Ladies' Home Journal* and *The Illustrated London News*. Advertisments were also drawn from three major archival collections: the Victoria and Albert Museum (V&A) in London, the British Library and the Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of American History. These institutions were chosen for their extensive holdings of historical advertisements and marketing ephemera, which are well-regarded resources in advertising history research. The British Library, for example, preserves several dedicated collections of Victorian and 20th-century advertisements including the Evanion collection and others curated by early collectors comprising thousands of posters, trade cards and print ads (Harland, 1987). Many of these have been digitised and made accessible online, providing a rich reservoir of material for analysis. Similarly, the Smithsonian Institution maintains vast archives of American advertising a search of the Smithsonian's catalogue reveals on the order of 18,000 artefacts related to advertising and brands (Beard, 2017). The V&A Museum, renowned for its focus on art and design, holds historical packaging and advertising designs as part of its collections, reflecting the aesthetic and commercial aspects of branding. By drawing from these three repositories as well, it ensured access to a diverse and representative corpus of cosmetic marketing materials spanning both British and North American contexts. This breadth mitigates the risk of focusing on one company's archives or a single publication, instead capturing a wide range of brands, product types and visual styles. The full list of advertisements analysed is presented in Appendix.

Rationale for time frame

The period 1880–1970 was selected for its historical significance in the evolution of advertising and its relevance to the research questions. Beginning in the late Victorian era (c. 1880) allows one to observe cosmetic advertising at the dawn of modern consumer culture. The late 19th century saw the rise of mass-produced personal care goods such as branded soaps and lotions and the expansion of print media that carried advertisements to a growing middle-class audience. By starting the sample in 1880, the study captures the formative years when such themes first became prominent in advertising discourse. The end point of 1970 was chosen to extend the analysis through the mid-20th century but stop before the advent of explicit environmental marketing in the late 20th century. In the 1960s, cosmetic advertising was still dominated by themes of beauty, femininity, science and nature's benefits, albeit in a more modern context (e.g. "natural" ingredients coexisting with scientific claims). Around the 1970s, however, the environmental movement and new regulations began to influence advertising (Hansen, 2002; Peattie and Crane, 2005). Ending the sample at 1970, thus, creates a historical baseline; it encompasses nearly a century of "nature" being used to sell beauty before the rise of contemporary green marketing and greenwashing. This makes it possible to later compare historical strategies to those of recent decades, highlighting continuities and changes. In sum, 1880–1970 is a period rich with

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transformations from Victorian morality to early 20th-century modernism to post-war consumer culture yet consistent in the underlying use of nature, purity and scientific progress as advertising appeals in the cosmetics realm.

Britain and the USA were global leaders in mass-market advertising, driven by rapid urbanisation, expanded literacy and the rise of illustrated periodicals (Tellis and Ambler, 2007). Studying British and American ads, thus, captures where many foundational strategies Mythologising natural purity, blending science with pastoral imagery first emerged on a large commercial scale. The marketing innovations established in these regions set trends that heavily influenced global advertising norms. Brands like Lever Brothers (the UK) or Pond's (the USA) exported not only their products but also their marketing aesthetics abroad, making British/American data pivotal for tracing the roots of global cosmetic advertising.

Archival research methodology and sampling approach

In historical marketing research, archival data provide primary evidence of past marketing practices and discourses (Ventresca and Mohr, 2017). The current approach follows established qualitative archival research methods. Rather than sampling statistically which is often not feasible with historical artefacts that survive in uneven patterns, purposive sampling was used to select advertisements that were relevant to the research focus (Coyne, 1997). The guiding criteria for inclusion were that an advertisement:

- promotes a cosmetic or personal care product (e.g. soap, skincare, haircare and makeup);
- uses imagery or copy related to nature, purity or similar themes; and
- falls within the 1880–1970 timeframe.
- Within these criteria, the aim was to capture variety across different decades, product categories and brands.

For each decade or significant period, multiple advertisements were sampled. The use of multiple archives helped ensure diversity: for instance, the V&A's collections yielded early printed trade cards and packaging labels with elaborate natural imagery, while the British Library's collections provided many Edwardian and interwar magazine ads, and the Smithsonian's holdings contributed mid-century American print ads. Deliberately attempts were made to seek out advertisements that would illuminate how "nature" was portrayed in different contexts from idyllic countryside scenes on 1890 s soap trade cards to scientific diagrams of plant extracts in 1950s skincare ads. In constructing the sample, materials were continually gathered until a point of redundancy was reached, where additional advertisements were no longer yielding new themes or visual strategies beyond those already observed. In qualitative research terms, this is akin to reaching data saturation (Lincoln and Guba, 1985). While not exhaustive, the sample size balances breadth and manageability it is large enough to encompass a range of examples over 90 years, yet focused enough to allow in-depth multimodal analysis of each item's imagery and text. We acknowledge that the surviving advertisements in archives are partly a function of what was preserved and collected; thus, the sample is inherently shaped by historical curation processes.

Study design

The selection criteria (Figure 1) targeted advertisements from late 19th- to early 20th-century British and American contexts that explicitly or implicitly featured natural ingredients, nature imagery or broader themes of purity and health. This ensured a diverse range of soaps, creams, powders and lotions, allowing for a representative view of how nature-based claims

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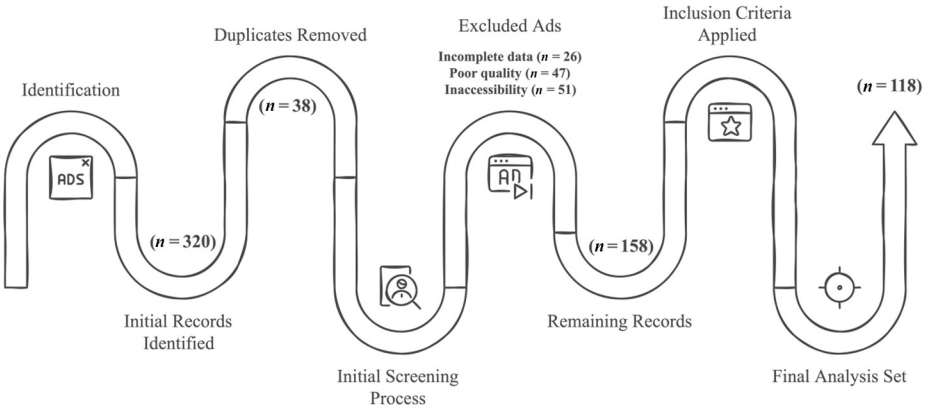


Figure 1. The process of selection for analysis
Source: Authors' own work

and aesthetics were deployed across different product categories. To examine how these ads constructed and communicated messages around "naturalness," the study adopts a MCDA framework (Machin and Mayr, 2012; Kress and van Leeuwen, 2020), which integrates several analytical dimensions under one cohesive approach. Visual-textual integration examines how colour palettes, layouts and symbolic motifs (e.g. flowers for purity) intersect with written slogans to create unified meanings (Olson *et al.*, 2008). Semiotic components analyse signs and symbols such as fonts, stylistic choices and iconography to reveal how advertisements reinforced cultural connotations of purity and authenticity (Chandler, 2007). The study also explores how ads embedded broader socio-cultural factors such as gender roles, consumer deception and the commodification of nature (Fairclough, 2013a, 2013b). Additionally, historical contextualisation helps situate these advertisements within their time and place, showing how anxieties around urbanisation and scientific progress shaped beauty marketing discourses. The "critical" aspect of MCDA means attention is paid to the ways discourse in ads naturalises certain values for instance, that "a woman's moral virtue is reflected in her natural beauty" or that "science and nature are in harmony when selling cosmetics" which might serve broader societal power structures such as gender norms or consumerist ideologies. By using MCDA, the analysis is positioned to uncover these latent meanings and the socio-historical contexts that produced them. This approach aligns with the discourse-historical perspective in that one considers the historical context of the advertisements (Wodak, 2001), but with an emphasis on decoding multimodal texts.

Data extraction and coding

Initially, each advertisement was catalogued with relevant details, including publication date, source, product type and brand. An open coding process identified recurring themes and motifs related to naturalness, femininity, science and packaging. Key features noted included visual elements like the use of natural imagery (flora, fauna and landscapes), depictions of women, colour schemes and typography; linguistic elements such as product names, slogans and descriptions emphasising natural ingredients or scientific claims; and representations of packaging that suggested sustainability or naturalness. Subsequently, a thematic analysis organised the coded data into themes aligning with the research questions: romanticisation of natural ingredients, the dual appeal of science and nature, gender roles and femininity, the

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power of tradition in Asian cosmetics and packaging strategies with greenwashing implications. Patterns and relationships between themes were identified, noting their evolution over time and differences across cultural contexts. An in-depth visual and semiotic analysis was then conducted on selected advertisements to deconstruct visual rhetoric and semiotic strategies. This involved analysing imagery and symbolism interpreting symbols like flowers representing purity, metaphors and allegories; examining composition and layout to understand how visual elements were arranged to guide viewer attention and convey messages; and exploring how colour palettes and font styles contributed to the overall meaning. The ethical implications and potential for consumer deception were assessed, focusing on the misrepresentation of product benefits and environmental claims. Comparisons were drawn between historical marketing strategies and contemporary greenwashing tactics, identifying continuities and changes. Finally, a cross-temporal was conducted, contrasting historical advertisements with modern examples to trace the evolution of marketing practices and analysing how British and American advertisements differed in their use of natural imagery and appeals, considering cultural values and societal norms.

Validity and reliability

To ensure the reliability and validity of the analysis, multiple sources and types of data were used, including advertisements from different regions and time periods. A consistent coding scheme was applied to all advertisements to minimise researcher bias. Preliminary findings were discussed with peers and experts in marketing history and visual analysis to validate interpretations. Historical texts and scholarly articles were used to contextualise findings and support interpretations, grounding the analysis in established theoretical frameworks (Skoog, 2023). While efforts were made to include a diverse range of advertisements, the sample may not capture all marketing practices of the period, especially from less-documented regions or smaller brands. The analysis of visual and semiotic elements involves subjective interpretation; however, awareness of this limitation was maintained. Access to some historical advertisements, particularly non-English ones, was challenging, potentially limiting the cultural scope of the analysis. All advertisements used in the study are in the public domain or reproduced under fair use for academic purposes. Care was taken to respect cultural contexts and avoid ethnocentric interpretations, particularly when analysing non-Western advertisements. While company names are mentioned to provide context, individual identities, such as models featured in the advertisements, were not the focus and were treated with respect.

The commodification of nature

Since the dawn of civilisation, nature's bounty has captivated human desire and fuelled economic ambition, from the aromatic spices of the Silk Road to the sparkling diamonds of African mines (Hancock, 2021). The process of assigning economic value to natural elements, known as the commodification of nature, has experienced notable growth since the onset of industrialisation. This transformation has significantly reshaped economies and has fundamentally redefined our relationship with the natural world. What was once cherished and protected has now turned into a resource to be exploited and a symbol to be manipulated. Throughout history, societies have thrived in close harmony with nature, deriving both sustenance and profound spiritual meaning from their environments (Mebratu, 1998). However, as industrial advances distanced people from the sources of their goods, a romantic yearning for the "natural" emerged. This desire surpassed mere nostalgia and evolved into a compelling marketing strategy. Companies started to romanticise natural ingredients, linking

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them to notions of purity and well-being. Naturalness evolved into a marker of authenticity in a world increasingly dominated by synthetic and mass-produced items. Consumers sought products that promised a genuine connection to nature, elevating natural goods to symbols of trustworthiness and integrity. Simultaneously, the use of nature as a symbol of luxury and sophistication became prevalent. High-end brands harnessed natural elements to convey exclusivity and elegance, transforming simple natural ingredients into highly sought-after commodities. By exploring these interconnected themes and referring to Figure 2, it is possible to unravel the intricate ways in which nature has been commodified.

Building on these Romantic ideals, a conceptual boundary between "human" and "nature" was continually redrawn as technologies advanced. In the essay *Illusory Boundary: Technology and the Environment*, it is highlighted that industrialising societies often softened their attitudes towards nature not by relinquishing control but by aestheticizing and commercialising the environment (Williams, 2014). That is, while nature was still subjected to human utility, it was simultaneously celebrated for its spiritual and restorative qualities. This dual impulse domination of the environment paired with a longing for pastoral purity helps explain the emergence of what we now call commodification: a process by which elements of nature (e.g. botanical extracts, mineral springs and scenic views) gain a market price or brand value. During the Victorian era, for example, writers and industrialists alike became adept at framing "pure nature" as not just a philosophical antidote to urban malaise but as a market advantage. Whether the sale involved farmland, fresh produce or nascent beauty products, the promise of closeness to nature carried substantial cultural cachet. Consumers who worried about adulteration or contamination in city life sought out items that claimed "natural origins" or "untouched purity" (Hancock, 2021). Marketers, in turn, cultivated these consumer desires and shaped them into potent selling propositions, effectively assigning economic value to symbolic elements like waterfalls, blossoms or fertile soil.

The term "mythical" in advertising refers to the elevated status given to certain products or ingredients, suggesting they possess extraordinary powers or qualities beyond their physical properties. This can be achieved through poetic, grand or spiritual language, suggesting

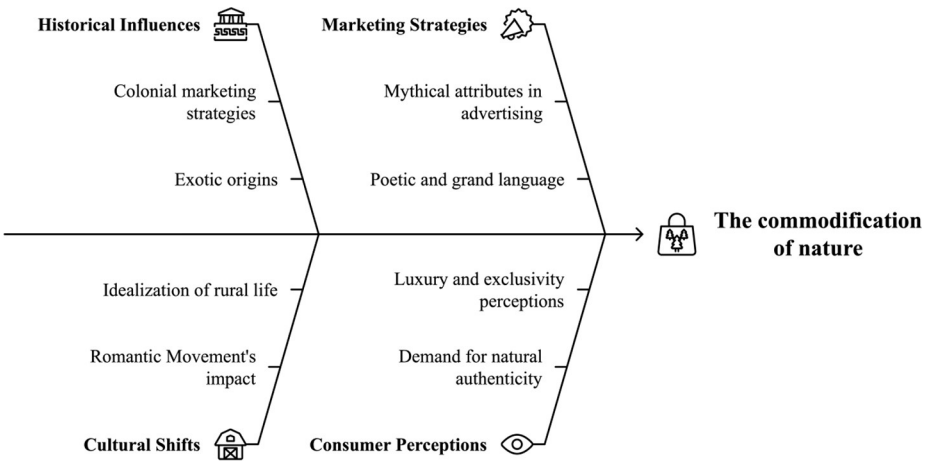


Figure 2. Transforming nature into a marketable asset
Source: Authors' own work

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miraculous transformations of the product. Beauty products often elevate natural ingredients like flowers, herbs or oils to a divine status, suggesting supernatural abilities to enhance beauty. Many contemporary brands selectively highlight natural ingredients. In many advertisements from this era, such as the one for Bourjois Java Face Powder, the imagery of an angel or cherub hovering over a woman, seemingly offering the powder with a magical touch is depicted [Figure 3(a)]. The cherub might be a representation of a deity or mythical figure, and its presence implies that supernatural forces have touched the product, giving it the ability to improve the user's beauty. The powder becomes not just a cosmetic, but something imbued with special, heavenly qualities. The fact that this cherub is shown handing the woman a brush, combined with the tagline "When Nature is Niggardly," implies that nature alone is not enough to bestow perfect beauty. Instead, this product, almost blessed by the cherub, acts as a divine solution to compensate for nature's shortcomings. Added to this is the association with "Ashes of Roses" evoking a romantic and poetic imagery of roses, which are often mythologised as symbols of beauty, love and perfection. By using this poetic term, the ad infuses the product with connotations of luxury, refinement and a deeper connection to both nature and mythical symbolism, elevating the mundane face powder to a product that enhances the wearer's beauty in a transcendent, almost otherworldly manner. This is further reinforced by phrases like "deep rich red in the heart of the rose" and "gleam of dew drops on



Figure 3. Nature as a marketable commodity

Sources: (a) When Nature is Niggardly – Adapted from The New York Times (public domain); (b) Cussons Talcum Powder – Adapted from Country Life (public domain); and (c) The Challenge – Adapted from The Review of Reviews (public domain)

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it," transforming the product into a vessel of nature's rarest and most precious qualities. A strong parallel can be drawn with the Cussons Talcum Powder from Country Life a British magazine which featured talcum powders in floral-scented varieties, such as "Blue Hyacinth," "Lilac Blossom" and "Apple Blossom" [Figure 3(b)]. The focus on these specific flowers lends a mythical, idealised quality to nature's fragrances, suggesting that their inclusion in the product will confer these natural, almost magical, qualities to the user. The mythical attributes of nature are thus commodified, as products claim to harness these elusive qualities and offer them to consumers in accessible, everyday forms. Today's beauty brands often use spiritual or celestial imagery in their packaging, product names and advertisements, drawing on the same idea of mythical empowerment. A popular serum "Unicorn Essence" uses the imagery of unicorns to suggest magical properties. The notion of applying "Unicorn Tears" to the skin appeals to a fantasy aesthetic, reminiscent of vintage advertisements featuring cherubs and other mythological figures. Similarly, a well-known moisturiser is presented as having near-miraculous effects, with the term "magic" being central to its branding. This implies that the results from the cream extend beyond standard cosmetic improvements, promising something extraordinary.

In many advertisements for Plantol Soap by Lever Brothers from 1905, natural ingredients were elevated to a nearly sacred status (The Sketch: A Journal of Art and Actuality, 1906). The soaps were highlighted as being crafted from "vegetable oils" and are explicitly stated to be "guaranteed to contain no animal fats." This choice of language positioned the product as not only effective but also ethically superior. During a time when industrialisation was frequently linked to pollution and moral decline, the emphasis on pure, natural ingredients provided a counter-narrative, promoting health and wholesomeness.

The 17th-century spice trade is a prime example of how marketers built on the captivating qualities of natural ingredients by associating products with historical or exotic sources to enhance their appeal. Spices such as cinnamon, nutmeg and cloves were valued for their not only flavours but also origins in mysterious, far-off lands. The Dutch and British East India Companies fuelled demand by weaving tales of exclusivity and adventure around these commodities. Drawing on historical events or tapping into exotic locations gives the product an aura of timelessness, evoking a sense of tradition, prestige and mystery. This technique often reflects societal trends where consumers sought to align themselves with global conquests or aristocratic ideals, particularly during the era of empire expansion when colonial narratives dominated much of popular discourse.

Many advertisements capitalised on the colonial narratives, presenting ingredients as sourced from the distant corners of the British Empire or other far-flung locations, creating an aura of exclusivity. The depiction of these ingredients often carries a notion of being rare, "culled from the flora of distant lands," as seen in an advertisement for Victorian Bouquet from 1897, which implied that the natural beauty and power of these faraway elements can be harnessed by consumers to enhance their own charm [Figure 3(c)]. Such a strategy taps into the exoticisation of the "other" that was prevalent in European colonial thinking, whereby the colonies were viewed as places of untouched nature and purity, in contrast to the industrialised Western world. Visually, advertisements bolster these associations through the inclusion of iconography such as colonial symbols, aristocratic figures or representations of historical epochs like the Victorian era. Such visual cues transport the consumer into a different time or place, suggesting that by using these products, they too can partake in this narrative of historical prestige. Product labels that showcase crests, crowns or royal endorsements create an impression of legitimacy and noble heritage, subtly associating the product with a higher social status. References to specific time periods, like the Victorian

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age, evoke imagery of refinement and propriety. This era's fascination with floral arrangements and perfumes enhances the product's luxurious and exotic qualities.

From a linguistic perspective, the use of terms like "imperial," "exotic" and "flora" in advertising texts enhances the product's narrative, implying that it goes beyond ordinary modern goods and is instead grounded in a deeper, more esteemed tradition. The rhetorical strategy here is clear: to sell not just a product but an experience that invokes the idyllic atmosphere of a historical or faraway place. Marketers skilfully use language that highlights the purity and richness of these ingredients, presenting them as magical or transformational elements. These tactics deserve careful examination as they transform both nature and culture into commodities, leveraging them as instruments to elevate a brand's story and standing in the market.

The ad for Yardley's English Lavender from the 1930s effectively showcases the English countryside, using imagery of pristine nature and the picturesque landscape to evoke a feeling of purity and authenticity. This link to the natural world evokes a vision of a perfect, historical England, untouched by industrialisation and modern pollution. The ad's language, such as "fresh from the English countryside," situates the product in a timeless, rural past, lending the product both natural credibility and cultural authenticity. Lavender, a plant long associated with English heritage, is strategically used to evoke both cultural familiarity and botanical exclusivity, making the product appear as a link between the user and a simpler, purer past. In modern contexts, this practice continues with variations. Consider the brand L'Occitane, a French beauty brand that heavily leans on its roots in Provence, France, often highlighting its use of traditional, time-honoured methods to harvest lavender, shea butter or immortelle flowers (Magnan, 2003). The brand connects itself to the quaint, idyllic countryside and the legacy of artisanal practices, suggesting that its products are the epitome of both history and natural luxury. The brand Aveda known for its plant-based products, regularly incorporates exotic origins into its marketing, such as sourcing rare ingredients from the Brazilian rainforest or India (Rechelbacher, 1999). This gives consumers the sense that they are accessing something both exotic and sustainable, despite the fact that the global sourcing practices often raise concerns about environmental sustainability.

Selling science: Authenticity cannot be manufactured

A tension arose between science and nature during the late 19th and early 20th centuries, when both fields were vying for public trust. Advertisements often emphasised the scientific legitimacy and purity of natural ingredients, contrasting modern advancements with the purity of nature (Figure 4). Research highlights how this duality tapped into the Victorian-era excitement for scientific advancements while also evoking the Romantic dream of pristine landscapes (Tala and Vesterinen, 2015). It emphasises the idea that nature's true worth could be measured and even enhanced through scientific methods. Companies would claim their ingredients have been clinically tested or derived through scientific processes, enhancing their efficacy while retaining their organic qualities. The emphasis on science and nature in beauty products led to a new narrative of trust, where consumers saw natural ingredients validated by scientific expertise as the ultimate marker of product quality. It was not just nature itself that was appealing, but nature that had been "perfected" by human knowledge and technological advancement (Richards, 1990). The message was that nature could be trusted because it was enhanced, measured and refined by modern science, creating a sense of safety, efficacy and credibility.

A dual appeal to both emotion and rationality was seen in many ads. For example, the "Palmolive Soap" advertisement, which was published in the early 1950s, promoted its inclusion of "Nature's Chlorophyll" as both a natural and scientific element, which

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Figure 4. Science versus nature

Sources: (a) Nature's Chlorophyll – Adapted from American Weekly (public domain); and (b) Her Herbal Preparations – Adapted from Harper's Bazaar (public domain)

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supposedly enhances the product's cleansing properties [Figure 4(a)]. The scientific terminology here operates as a rhetorical device, intended to imbue the product with a sense of credibility and effectiveness. This tactic aligns with what is described as the "semiotic use of science," where scientific language and imagery are used to create a veneer of factual authority, even when the claims are vague or misleading (Lawes, 2018). Studies of early advertising discourse have shown that mention of specific chemical or biological terms regardless of scientific accuracy often boosted consumer trust in an era when science was increasingly revered (Belova *et al.*, 2015; Weigold, 2001).

Vintage advertisements often included scientific elements like laboratory settings, beakers and white-coated technicians to legitimise their claims of naturalness. Such visual clichés deliberately capitalised on public growing faith in scientific institutions, thereby combining emotional "green" appeals with logical evidence. Such visual cues helped to convey that these products were not just whimsically inspired by nature but were scientifically engineered to offer reliable and consistent results. Advertisements often stressed that these products were not simply harvested from the earth but rather meticulously refined or "scientifically distilled" for maximum potency. The rhetoric surrounding these products suggested that nature on its own might not be enough; science was needed to unlock its true potential, making the product both "natural" and "trustworthy" by modern standards. A 1930 Frances Denney advertisement as seen in Figure 4(b) showcases the blend of scientific legitimacy and natural essence of herbal preparations. The ad presents these products as the result of extensive research and experimentation. Historical analyses show that such depictions catered to a growing cultural fascination with "rational progress," reassuring consumers that new scientific methods would preserve and enhance nature's virtues. The reference to herbal extractions and the evocation of "ancient times" emphasises the refinement of nature's offerings, enhancing the product's authenticity and positioning it as innovative and timeless.

In the post-war era, particularly in the mid-20th century, the fear of chemical exposure began to influence consumer preferences, and advertisements played on this anxiety by

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emphasising naturalness as not just an aesthetic or romantic ideal but a guarantee of safety. This shift coincided with heightened public concern about toxicity and pollutants, documented in environmental histories that cite post-war consumer distrust of synthetic materials (Cohen, 2004). The growing mistrust of synthetic materials and chemical additives led to marketing strategies that promoted natural products as non-toxic, hypoallergenic and health-preserving. Advertisers effectively connected with both nature and science, instilling confidence in consumers that their products represented the safer and more genuine option in a world that is becoming increasingly industrialised and laden with chemicals. Pond's Extract Company is one example of an advertising narrative that successfully blended the growing belief in scientific preparation with natural remedies (Jones, 2011). At the heart of their marketing strategy was witch hazel extract, a remarkable product known for its healing and soothing properties, widely recognised as a natural remedy for various skin concerns. Historical marketing records show that major cosmetic brands pivoted to highlight "science-backed nature" around this time, underscoring consumer desire for verifiable product claims. To effectively reach a rapidly expanding consumer base increasingly aware of the benefits of modern science, Pond's ads highlighted that their witch hazel was not merely a typical botanical remedy; it was meticulously crafted in a laboratory environment. Their advertisements often highlighted laboratory settings, filled with visuals of glass beakers, test tubes and technicians in white coats, emphasising the idea that the product was purified, standardised and meticulously controlled. Through the display of these laboratory preparations, the brand guaranteed consumers the purity and effectiveness of the extract. This dual approach, blending nature and science, allowed Pond's to cater to a Victorian-era desire for both authentic natural remedies and scientific legitimacy. The laboratory imagery served to elevate witch hazel from a simple household remedy to a product of modern innovation, designed with precision and care, thus reinforcing its authenticity and trustworthiness in an era when consumers were increasingly concerned with the safety and quality of their purchases.

Naturalness as a Marker of Authenticity remains a compelling strategy. Marketing theorists highlight that authenticity is a socially constructed concept, wherein consumers place faith in brands that demonstrate alignment with cultural values (Haugtvedt *et al.*, 2014). Today, consumers are increasingly informed and conscious about what they apply to their bodies, which has significantly enhanced the marketing attraction of "natural" products. Brands leverage naturalness to not only differentiate themselves in the marketplace but also establish an emotional connection with consumers, often equating natural ingredients with health, sustainability and safety. Brands like Burt's Bees, Lush and The Body Shop emphasise their use of natural ingredients, often positioning them as safer and more environmentally friendly than synthetic alternatives. For example, Burt's Bees frequently highlights its use of beeswax and natural oils, playing into the idea that products derived from nature are inherently better for the skin. These companies often promote their ingredients as sustainably sourced, reinforcing an image of authenticity and purity that appeals to health-conscious consumers. Even mass-market brands like L'Oréal's Garnier or Neutrogena's Naturals line highlight their reliance on natural, often sustainably sourced ingredients. These brands use visuals of plants, fruits and herbs on their packaging, emphasising simplicity and a "return to nature" to appeal to health-conscious consumers. This visual and linguistic focus on naturalness serves to differentiate these products from others that are perceived to be overly synthetic or chemical-laden. The rise of the clean beauty movement is perhaps the most prominent example of how naturalness is intertwined with authenticity in the modern cosmetics industry. Brands like Herbivore Botanicals or Biossance claim to be "clean" and "non-toxic," often equating these qualities with natural

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ingredients that are free from parabens, sulphates and synthetic fragrances. The promise of authenticity here stems from the belief that clean, natural products are inherently better for both the body and the environment, though in many cases, these claims are more marketing-oriented than scientifically substantiated.

A useful theoretical framework is provided by the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986). The ELM suggests that people process persuasive messages through two routes: the central route, which involves thoughtful content consideration, and the peripheral route, influenced by surface-level cues like imagery or aesthetics. In the context of naturalness in advertising, peripheral cues like botanical visuals or claims of "all-natural ingredients" often serve to influence consumers without requiring deeper cognitive engagement. Marketers exploit these heuristics by combining authoritative science references (white coats, clinical language) with tranquil nature imagery, effectively targeting both rational and emotive decision-making. This framework helps to explain why natural imagery and language are so effective in shaping consumer attitudes, even when substantive information regarding the actual product or its efficacy may be lacking. Even in the absence of substantial facts, scientific language and images were shown to increase the perceived trustworthiness of products (Rendell *et al.*, 2021). Similarly, commercials that emphasise naturalness appeal to consumers' emotional and heuristic processing, eliciting connections with safety and trust. According to research, customers typically consider items tied to nature or tradition as more dependable, regardless of their actual content (Zhang and Dong, 2020). Hence, the ELM framework not only explains the persuasive potency of combining science and nature but also signals the ethical complexities when such tactics are leveraged without transparent evidence. The ELM framework helps explain why naturalness continues to be an effective marketing tool in both vintage and modern contexts.

Gender roles and femininity

The representation of gender and femininity in beauty advertising has historically been deeply intertwined with notions of naturalness, purity and care, reinforcing broader marketing strategies that commodify nature. The idealised vision of femininity presented in advertisements does not exist in isolation it is strategically constructed to align with commercial narratives that present beauty as both a natural attribute and a cultivated product. Advertisers used a range of semiotic tools to construct a highly idealised vision of femininity, often centred around notions of purity, gentleness and domesticity. Women were often portrayed as soft, delicate and often passive figures. This was achieved through the careful use of colour schemes where light pastels or neutral tones dominate, symbolising innocence and natural beauty. Women were frequently seen in domestic settings, engaged in traditionally feminine activities such as applying beauty products or caring for the household. The repetitive imagery of flowers, soft fabrics and gentle motions further underlines the associations of femininity with nature, care and nurture. These signs created a myth of femininity, where womanhood is equated with softness and naturalness, creating a gendered expectation that women should embody these ideals (Brownmiller, 2013). The use of language is notable for its emphasis on care, mildness and safety often positioning women as guardians of both their appearance and the domestic space. Terms such as "safe for your skin," "mild" and "gentle" appear frequently, implying that women's beauty and femininity are inherently fragile and in need of protection. This aligns with broader social narratives of the time, where women were expected to be nurturing and caring, for not only themselves but also their families. This creates a duality in the representation of femininity: women are portrayed as both delicate and powerful in their role as caretakers.

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This is apparent in the 1941 advertisement for "Raspberry Ice" by Charles of the Ritz [Figure 5(a)] which exemplifies a highly gendered portrayal of femininity, using visual and textual cues that reflect societal expectations of the time. The female figure, positioned at a soda fountain, is drawn with exaggerated curves, emphasising her hyper-feminised silhouette. Her posture, seated and seemingly engrossed in a leisurely activity, reinforces the notion of women as passive consumers of beauty rituals rather than active agents. The visual focus on the waist and hips, accentuated by the fitted dress, plays into traditional gender roles that value women primarily for their appearance. The male figure, depicted with a moustache and formal attire, contrasts the woman's softer, more vibrant image, further cementing the gendered binary of strength versus delicacy. The textual description of the product also frames femininity in terms of indulgence and allure words like "whipped up" and "delicious" imply that a woman's charm is something to be consumed, much like the product itself. This advertisement, while promoting a cosmetic item, also promotes a very specific idea of femininity, one that is tied to beauty, passivity and the consumption of products designed to enhance physical appeal.

The marketing of femininity as an inherently natural state has also created a paradox in beauty advertising: while women are framed as naturally beautiful, they are simultaneously made to feel reliant on products to maintain that beauty. This contradiction is at the core of both historical cosmetic marketing and contemporary greenwashing practices. The Frances Denney Herbal Preparations advertisement is another example that simultaneously promoted



Figure 5. Female social norms

Sources: (a) New! For Fresh, Delicious, Summer Charm… Raspberry Ice – Adapted from Vogue (public domain); and (b) Be as Modern as You Like – Adapted from Harper's Bazaar (public domain) Images sourced from Penn State University Libraries and the Ad*Access Digital Collection (Duke University Libraries). Public domain content; free for reuse

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femininity in accordance with conventional beauty standards and encouraged women to embrace modernity and versatility, as symbolised by the woman playing golf [Figure 5(b)]. The text reassures women that they can engage in outdoor activities and still "be lovely," subtly reinforcing the expectation that no matter how modern or liberated a woman becomes, her primary responsibility remains maintaining her appearance. The visual and textual contrast is stark. The image of the woman engaged in a sport typically associated with male leisure, juxtaposed with the emphasis on herbal beauty treatments, suggests that modern femininity is multifaceted but must still conform to societal beauty ideals. The use of words like "lovely" and "charm" reflects this underlying tension between newfound freedom and deeply entrenched beauty norms. Moreover, the focus on "herbal" ingredients speaks to the early 20th-century shift towards "natural" beauty remedies, symbolising authenticity and purity. However, this also introduces the modern consumer to the idea that even the liberated, modern woman requires external products to achieve the ideal feminine appearance, creating a dependency on beauty rituals to navigate modernity.

Although these historical ads were not explicitly discussing environmental sustainability, they laid the conceptual framework that nature is inherently beneficial and intimately tied to the feminine ideal. In today's beauty industry, advertisers frequently evoke "clean," "organic" or "nature-based" descriptors to suggest that products will nurture rather than harm women's bodies. Additionally, the long-standing idea of "protecting delicate femininity" through soft, nature-based formulas continues to influence today's marketing messages. These often portray women as particularly susceptible to synthetic chemicals, which can lead to feelings of shame around non-natural options, all while failing to provide real clarity about what's in the products or where they come from. Ultimately, the historical construction of femininity as both natural and in need of enhancement laid the groundwork for today's greenwashing in the beauty industry. Whether through mid-century ads promoting "safe and gentle" creams or modern campaigns selling "clean and non-toxic" serums, the message remains the same: women's beauty is an asset, and nature real or imagined will always be used to sell it.

Packaging tricks: a clever disguise for what's underneath

The cosmetics industry started to see packaging for what it is: a powerful tool to attract customers and convey messaging. Packaging not only protected the product but also served as a visual representation of the brand's values and promises. Green marketing research confirms that packaging has a strong influence on consumer perceptions of environmental friendliness and brand credibility (Duarte *et al.*, 2024; Reddy *et al.*, 2023). For many shoppers, the look and feel of a box, tin or bottle serves as the first physical and visual cues as to whether a product truly aligns with the "natural" ideals it advertises. During this period, advertisers used various packaging strategies showcased in the advertisements to emphasise naturalness and sustainability, even if the broader environmental implications were neglected. Rather than focusing on the actual composition of boxes or bottles, early marketers drew attention to the idea of packaging as ethically superior or "closer to nature," effectively translating packaging aesthetics into a potent sales pitch. Companies often used glass, paper and metal for packaging, seen as closer to nature and more authentic than synthetic materials. Lux Toilet Soap [Figure 6 (c)], for instance, came in elegant metal tins, which exuded sophistication while also reinforcing the idea of purity and long-lasting quality. Similarly, the use of glass in Pixavon Shampoo bottles [Figure 6 (a)] allowed consumers to see the product, reinforcing transparency and natural appeal, while earthy colours and flowing lines in the packaging suggested organic, natural ingredients. These materials also stood in contrast to synthetic alternatives, such as plastics, which were

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Figure 6. Packaging strategies in the early 20th century

Sources: (a) Daisy – Adapted from Illustrirte Zeitung (public domain); (b) Airspun Coty Loose Face Powder – Adapted from The Australian Women's Weekly (public domain); and (c) Marvellous Value! – Adapted from Lux Soaps advertisement (public domain)

Images sourced from the Collection of Stephanie Bender, Trove (National Library of Australia) and The National Archives. Public domain content; free for reuse

beginning to signal to consumers that these products were closer to nature. By emphasising these eco-like attributes, advertisers invited consumers to infer that the entire product and by extension, the brand was in harmony with the environment. In effect, the advertisement itself was a stage upon which packaging performed the role of "green credential," turning an ordinary container into a symbol of moral virtue and timeless craftsmanship.

The use of earthy colours and textures, like muted greens, browns and pastels, reinforced this connection to nature. These tones were chosen deliberately to evoke calm, simplicity and an organic feel. Packaging with matte finishes and textured papers suggested a more "raw" or "natural" approach, contrasting the glossy and polished aesthetics often associated with synthetic beauty products. Typography that mimicked handwritten fonts gave products a personal and artisanal feel, suggesting that these were crafted with care and attention to natural processes rather than mass-produced. Rounded edges and flowing lines in the designs also emphasised harmony with nature, contrasting the harsh geometric shapes of modern, industrial design. Take, for example, Coty's Air-Spun Face Powder [Figure 6 (b)], which featured delicate floral motifs to further emphasise naturalness and reinforce these associations. The choice of typography also added to this effect; handwritten fonts and gentle curves in the design fostered a personal, delicate feel. Finally, narrative elements played a significant role. Packaging often included brief stories or references to traditional recipes, highlighting the product's use of time-honoured natural ingredients. These narratives created a deeper emotional connection, appealing to the consumer's desire for authenticity and a return to simpler, more natural times. For example, references to beekeepers or traditional herbalists emphasised the idea of natural sourcing, even when the products contained synthetic additives. These stories subtly manipulated consumer perception, fostering trust in the brand's commitment to nature, much like modern greenwashing strategies.

Latest instances show how companies continue to use eco-friendly packaging and natural imagery to influence how consumers see them. A critical example is Innisfree, a prominent South Korean beauty brand. In 2021, Innisfree was exposed for falsely marketing its "paper

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bottle" packaging. Upon investigation, it was revealed that the paper bottle actually concealed a plastic bottle inside, a deceptive tactic that sparked consumer outrage and accusations of greenwashing (BBC News, 2021). Jessica Alba co-founded the Honest Company, and its case serves as a crucial illustration of how greenwashing can have serious legal repercussions (Çam, 2021). In 2017, the company agreed to settle a lawsuit for $7.35m after being accused of misleading consumers by falsely labelling products as "natural," despite including synthetic chemicals in the formulation. Figure 7 illustrates a balanced perspective on the potential pros and cons of green packaging strategies in cosmetic advertising. While the ethical appeal of environmental branding can enhance consumer trust and loyalty, there remains a significant risk of greenwashing. By tracking these parallels, it becomes evident that packaging emphasis in ads whether in 1890 or 2025 serves as a compelling rhetorical tactic to influence consumer beliefs about a product's authenticity, safety and eco-friendliness. Even without dissecting the package's physical components, the advertisement's deliberate focus on "earth-friendly" exteriors invites consumers to conflate appearance with reality. Such conflation is precisely what greenwashing exploits: the gap between image and substance that arises when companies leverage natural cues for marketing advantage without delivering equivalent ecological benefits.

Conclusion, implications for greenwashing and ethical considerations

By using MCDA, this study has illuminated how cosmetic advertisements from 1880 to 1970 constructed compelling discourses that intertwine nature, beauty, femininity and morality and how these historical discourses find echoes in today's green marketing and greenwashing. It was found that during this time, marketers took advantage of people's fears about the effects of fast industrialisation and urbanisation by analysing a data set of ads from that era. Historical factors have shaped the way advertisers present nature, depicting it as a

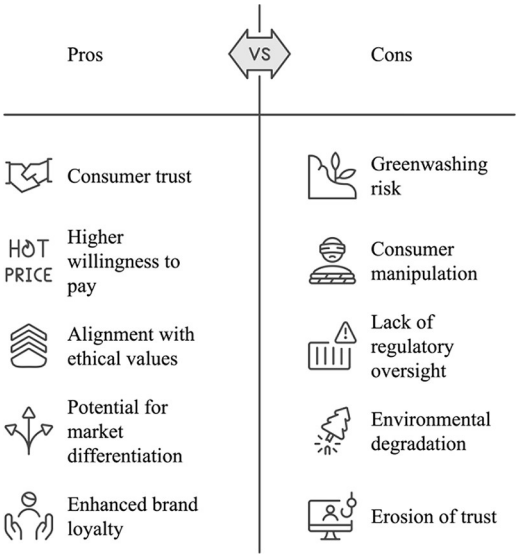


Figure 7. Pros and cons of eco-friendly packaging in cosmetic marketing
Source: Authors' own work

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source of purity, health and beauty that effectively counters the perceived ills of modern living. The early strategies played an instrumental part in commercialising the environment and set the stage for the modern greenwashing practices that will be explored in this section. Grasping this historical trajectory sheds light on the evolution of marketing strategies and highlights the urgent necessity for more authentic and accountable practices in the future.

Both in the past and today, marketing that uses mythical narratives can manipulate consumers into thinking they are purchasing products that are more natural or effective than they truly are. This emotional pull places profit above transparency, fostering an environment ripe for greenwashing. Just as mythical imagery can suggest impossible beauty ideals, the same logic applies in greenwashing when consumers are made to feel that their personal choices (like buying a particular shampoo or body wash) can significantly contribute to saving the planet. This approach unfairly shifts the responsibility onto individuals instead of tackling the larger systemic challenges that impact environmental sustainability. Linking products to exotic or historical origins instils a perception of rarity, uniqueness and superior quality among consumers. Historical references evoke nostalgia, which is often linked to higher consumer trust and willingness to pay a premium (Dam *et al.*, 2024; Jiang *et al.*, 2023; Li *et al.*, 2019). These marketing tactics effectively tap into consumer desires for exclusivity and escapism, regardless of whether the practical value of the product aligns with the elevated narrative presented. Modern marketing often promotes exotic sourcing of ingredients as part of a brand's eco-conscious appeal. It is important to recognise that these practices may serve as a form of greenwashing, especially when the true environmental or social consequences of sourcing from exotic locations are obscured or minimised. Brands often tout their sustainability by highlighting "unprocessed or "rare" ingredients, yet they frequently conceal the environmental harm or exploitation that accompanies their acquisition. Consider a brand that promotes an ingredient as sourced from a "untouched" rainforest, appealing to consumers' longing for authenticity, yet conveniently overlooking the realities of deforestation and labour exploitation tied to its sourcing.

Naturalness has evolved significantly becoming a key tenet of brand positioning, particularly for companies in the beauty, food, fashion and wellness industries (Binninger, 2015; Dahanayake *et al.*, 2023; Frizzo *et al.*, 2020; Murdoch and Miele, 1999). The consumer landscape has transformed significantly as a new generation of buyers, especially millennials and Generation Z, emerges. These consumers are more informed and ethically driven, placing a high value on authenticity, transparency and sustainability in the products they choose to purchase (Chang *et al.*, 2024; Cosgrave and O'Dwyer, 2020; Marschlich and Dhanesh, 2024). Natural ingredients are often used as trust markers for brands, indicating their commitment. However, this reliance on such markers brings to light significant concerns regarding corporate accountability, the potential for consumer manipulation and the risk of greenwashing. Naturalness is frequently associated with trust and a sense of genuine authenticity (Napoli *et al.*, 2016). Modern consumers frequently associate the term "natural" with essential qualities like safety, quality and ethical responsibility. This association serves as a compelling advantage for companies aiming to build and enhance consumer trust. The psychological draw of naturalness is grounded in the perception that natural products are inherently better for both individual health and the planet (Iannuzzi, 2024). This is especially important now, as consumers are becoming more and more doubtful of large corporations, which are frequently viewed as profit-driven organisations that disregard ethical considerations. Companies can effectively leverage consumer scepticism by positioning their products as natural, showcasing honesty and transparency qualities that deeply resonate with modern buyers. While natural ingredients can indeed signal authenticity, there is growing concern that many of these claims are marketing gimmicks. The wellness

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movement, which places a premium on "clean" and "natural" living, is a driving force behind this trend, with brands across multiple sectors from skincare to food capitalising on the association between natural products and holistic health (Crawford and Leventis, 2005; Van Buul and Brouns, 2013). The issue here, though, is that many of the health claims made by companies remain scientifically unverified, raising questions about the legitimacy of these purported benefits. For example, products marketed as "natural" or "organic" may still contain harmful preservatives or other synthetic additives, thus challenging the notion that natural equates to healthier or more ethical. This tension between perception and reality forms a critical part of the debate surrounding naturalness as a marketing strategy.

Beyond health concerns, the idea of naturalness is closely linked to the increasing demand for sustainability and environmental responsibility. Consumers are actively seeking natural products and demand that brands showcase their dedication to environmentally friendly practices (Ottman, 2011). However, this is precisely where greenwashing poses a major problem. Many brands claim to be "eco-friendly," "all-natural" or "sustainably sourced," yet often fail to meet the stringent environmental standards these labels suggest. The "natural" label often becomes a smokescreen for unsustainable practices that undermine the very authenticity that brands are attempting to project (Montgomery *et al.*, 2023). Brands frequently leverage buzzwords such as "organic," "natural" or "green," fully aware that these terms strongly appeal to consumers who prioritise ethical and environmentally responsible options (Evans and Peirson-Smith, 2018). The absence of regulatory oversight concerning the use of these terms enables companies to make inflated or completely false claims, exploiting consumer demand for genuine, eco-friendly products while failing to fulfil those commitments. This not only erodes consumer trust but also dilutes the meaning of naturalness in the marketplace, rendering it a superficial marketing tactic rather than a marker of genuine ethical commitment (Seele and Gatti, 2015). This approach ultimately erodes the trustworthiness of the brand and the very idea of naturalness.

With consumers increasingly recognising the risks of greenwashing, there is a growing demand for reliable and verifiable information regarding the products they choose to buy. Companies have an opportunity to stand out by embracing transparency and sustainability. By offering comprehensive details about the sourcing, production and environmental impact of their products, they can truly set themselves apart in the marketplace. At the same time, brands must recognise that authenticity cannot be manufactured through clever marketing alone. True authenticity is rooted in sincere ethical practices, such as sustainable sourcing, fair labour and environmentally responsible production processes. Companies that do not substantiate their natural claims with genuine actions are likely to distance themselves from their consumers and undermine trust in the market.

The concept of scientification in marketing, as identified by Kenalemang-Palm and Eriksson (2023), also has its historical antecedent. In the mid-20th century ads, there was a strong trend of what one could call proto-scientification ads increasingly featured laboratory imagery, endorsements from "experts," technical diagrams of how a product works and mentions of scientific tests. In the current sample, especially by the 1950s and 1960s, it was common for beauty ads to include references to vitamins, chemical compounds (e.g. "contains keratin protein" or "pH balanced") and laboratory settings in visuals. This gave consumers a sense that modern science was delivering the secrets of nature in a bottle a highly effective discourse merging trust in science with trust in nature. Modern greenwashing uses the same playbook: many "green" beauty products are advertised with scientific-sounding buzzwords ("plant stem cells", "marine collagen" and "clinically proven formula") right alongside eco-friendly cues (green leaves, recycling symbols and claims of "all-natural"). The purpose is analogous to reduce scepticism. If consumers might doubt a

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purely scientific, chemical-laden product, then adding "natural" makes it seem gentle and safe; if they might doubt a purely natural remedy's efficacy, then adding "science" makes it seem effective and advanced. It is a double reinforcement. For instance, a 2024 skincare ad might feature a model in a white lab coat holding a plant or mention "patented botanical technology". Kenalemang-Palm and Eriksson (2023) specifically found that green anti-ageing cosmetics online "connote science while glossing over significant details" and leave actual processes unexplained, which is a hallmark of scientification in greenwashing. The goal is to create an impression of scientific legitimacy without necessarily providing scientific substantiation a tactic that relies on the consumer's positive associations with science.

Women continue to be the primary targets of greenwashing in the beauty industry, a pattern deeply rooted in historical marketing narratives. The expectation to "choose ethical products" is disproportionately placed on female consumers, reinforcing long-standing societal associations between femininity, purity, morality and environmental stewardship. Much like early beauty advertising emphasised women's responsibility for maintaining their appearance, contemporary eco-friendly beauty brands frame sustainability as an individual choice rather than a corporate responsibility.

Modern "clean beauty" campaigns frequently position their products as empowering, implying that women can "take control" of their health and the environment by opting for natural, toxin-free or eco-conscious alternatives. However, this rhetoric deflects accountability away from corporations, shifting the responsibility of ethical consumption onto individuals rather than addressing systemic environmental issues. Just as historical beauty ads reinforced the notion that feminine beauty required careful curation, today's sustainability messaging constructs an illusion that purchasing "green" beauty products is an act of ethical womanhood, despite the lack of transparency or true commitment to sustainable practices (Wolf, 2013). Future research should explore how greenwashing intersects with gendered consumer pressures and how brands can promote authentic sustainability without reinforcing outdated stereotypes.

Companies often showcase positive environmental attributes while hiding the negative. This cherry-picking approach overlooks essential information regarding the product's environmental impact (Chiras, 2013). Brands often emphasise biodegradable packaging, yet their production processes may rely on unsustainable practices. This selective disclosure misleads consumers into believing that the entire product is eco-friendly. Another prime concern is the opacity in supply chains. Packaging becomes a distraction, misleading consumers who may assume ethical sourcing and manufacturing are part of the process. A study by TerraChoice found that over 95% of products claiming to be green were guilty of at least one "sin of greenwashing," including hidden trade-offs and a lack of proof. This highlights how selective information feeds consumer deception (Terrachoice, 2010). Ethically, companies have a responsibility to provide accurate and comprehensive information about their products; deceptive packaging undermines this duty. In a corporate social responsibility framework, transparency is essential, and companies failing to disclose full information risk backlash, especially as consumers become more aware of greenwashing tactics. Research clearly shows that dishonest packaging practices can significantly undermine long-term consumer loyalty (Jones, 2019; Wilkins *et al.*, 2016). In developing markets, the impact of deceptive packaging can be significantly greater because of the often-weaker regulatory oversight. Consumers in these regions encounter significant obstacles in obtaining reliable product information, which only deepens existing inequalities.

Many packaging tactics exploit the human mind's cognitive tendencies, such as the halo effect (Thorndike, 1920). One positive attribute, such as the environmentally friendly packaging of a shampoo bottle, can significantly improve the overall perception of the product. It is

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intriguing to consider how this leverages our inclination to prioritise environmental responsibility, to the point where we may overlook the larger environmental repercussions of the product. Additionally, there is the bias of green consumerism, in which environmentally conscious consumers may focus on minor aspects like biodegradable packaging without fully understanding the overall environmental footprint of the product (Gleim and Lawson, 2014). The visual simplicity of packaging is powerful, as it reduces complex data into digestible symbols, which consumers may accept uncritically. The sentiment evoked by environmentally friendly visuals can override a logical assessment of the actual environmental effects of a product (Wang *et al.*, 2022). Misleading packaging that appears eco-friendly gives the illusion of environmental improvement, leading consumers to underestimate the true impact and reduce their demand for meaningful changes from companies. As a result, the drive to adopt authentic sustainable measures diminishes, impeding progress in environmental preservation. From a utilitarian perspective, deceptive packaging serves the company's immediate interests but at the expense of both consumer welfare and environmental health (Mill, 1863). The emphasis on profit-driven motives neglects the broader societal good. Companies prioritising superficial green claims fail to address the larger environmental crisis, contributing to ongoing harm through misinformation. Ethically, the focus should be on the greatest good honesty and sustainability for long-term societal benefit rather than short-term profit maximisation. While using the appeal of being natural may be an effective marketing tool, it often conceals the environmental realities of the products being sold.

Future scholarship can extend these historical insights by conducting longitudinal or cross-cultural examinations of greenwashing rhetoric. Investigating consumer susceptibility to natural imagery can further reveal how cultural myths of purity evolve with technological and social shifts. Brands that embrace verifiable transparency detailing supply chains, environmental footprints and honest sourcing can build trust in increasingly sceptical markets. Marketers should move beyond superficial "green" signifiers, ensuring their natural claims align with genuine environmental commitments. Regulators and advocacy groups can push for stringent guidelines on the use of "natural" or "organic" labels, reducing ambiguity and providing consumers with more reliable information. In emerging markets with weaker oversight, policy interventions could promote third-party audits and standardised certifications, countering deceptive eco-claims that exploit consumer vulnerability.

Ultimately, today's greenwashing controversies echo patterns established over a century ago. Recognising this legacy reveals that "natural" beauty has always been as much a cultural narrative as a factual claim, making it susceptible to manipulation. By situating current marketing practices within its historical context, we underscore the ethical imperative for authenticity backed by transparent evidence and accountable practices. Moving forward, an informed public, combined with proactive corporate and policy measures, can help ensure that nature is not merely a marketing ploy but a genuine commitment to sustainability and social responsibility.

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Appendix

Table A1. Year and source of advertisements

Title	Date	Company	Product	Source
Poster for la Poudre de Riz la Diaphane	1836	la Diaphane	Face powder	The New York Public Library
Gowland's Lotion	1839	Gowland's	Skin Lotion	British Library Archives
Lillie Powder for the Complexion	1840	W. Clarkson	Face Powder	History of Advertising Trust
Crayon Rubens for the Hair	1851	S. Bocinski	Hair Dye	Illustrirte Zeitung, Open Library of Humanities
Dr. Simms' Arsenic Complexion Wafers	1858	Dr. Simms	Skin Lightening Tablets	The New York Public Library
Madame Rachel's "Magnetic Rock Dew of the Sahara"	1863	Madame Rachel (Sarah Russell)	Anti-aging Elixir	Historical Accounts of Madame Rachel
Rowland's Macassar Oil	1870	Rowland & Son	Hair Oil	Cornell University Library
Bunter's Preparations For The Teeth	1880	A Wilson, London	Toothpaste	The History of Advertising Trust Archive
Goodwin's of Manchester	1880	Goodwins' toilet soap	Toilet soap	The Illustrated London News
Peerless Erasmic Soap	1880	Herb Toilet Soap	Soap	The Illustrated London News
Aspinall's Neigeline Skin Lotion	1890	Aspinall's Neigeline	Cosmetics and toiletries	Hulton Archive
Vinolia Otto Toilet Soap	1890	Vinolia	Soap	The Druggists' Circular and Chemical Gazette
Beetham's Cucumber and Glycerine Cream	1890	Beetham's	Creams and lotions	The Illustrated London News
Delicious New Perfume, Crab Apple Blossoms	1890	CROWN PERFUMERY CO.	Perfume	The Illustrated London News
Doubling our business in a short time	1892	Vintage Fels & Co.	Toilet Soap	The Druggists Circular and Chemical Gazette
Mrs. Gervaise Graham's Cucumber and Elder Flower Cream	1892	Mrs. Gervaise Graham	Creams and lotions	Cornell University Library
Purest. Safest. Best	1892	Vinolia	Soap	The Druggists Circular and Chemical Gazette
Art nouveau poster for Lundborg's Perfumes	1894	Lundborg's Perfumes	Perfume	Cambridge University Press
Victorian Bouquet	1897	Grossmiths & Sons	Perfume	The Review of Reviews
As morning roses newly washed with dew' Taming of the Shrew. Lever Brothers Ltd, Port Sunlight	1905	Plantol soap	Soap	History of Advertising Trust
Made from the choicest products of fruit and flowers. Lever Brothers Ltd, Port Sunlight	1905	Plantol soap	Soap	The Sphere
"Modern Girl" motif.	1910	Ponds	Soap	The Sphere
Hazeline Snow Cream	1920	Burroughs & Wellcome	Skin Cream	The Collector

(*continued*)

Table A1. Continued

Title	Date	Company	Product	Source
Phine Violets	1920	Mülhen perfumes	Perfume	United Archives
Complexions–Night and Noon	1921	Palmolive Company	Soap	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
As The Sun Draws Out The Beauty of Nature, Boncilla Brings Out Your Natural Beauty	1922	Boncilla Laboratories, Inc.	Boncilla Cosmetics	McCall's
How to care for the skin? Let this well-known physician answer:	1922	Procter & Gamble Co.	Ivory Soap	Curiosity Digital Collections
When Nature is Niggardly	1922	Bourjois	Java face powder	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
"How dainty"	1923	Procter & Gamble Co.	Guest Ivory Soap	Library of Congress
Where Beauty Begins	1923	Palmolive Company	Soap	Motion Picture Digital Collections
"Good health and pure soap"–the simple formula for a beautiful skin	1924	Procter & Gamble Co.	Guest Ivory Soap	Holland's Magazine
Did Nature fail to put roses in your cheeks?	1924	Pompeian Bloom	Rouge	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
Good health and pure soap"–the simple formula for a beautiful skin	1924	Procter & Gamble Co.	Ivory Soap	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
Skin fatigue is the foe of beauty. The Health Doctor tells how to avoid it	1924	Lever Brothers Company	Lifebuoy Health Soap	Ladies' Home Journal
Bourjois Manon Lescaut Face Powder; Ashes of Roses Rouge; Rouge Mandarine	1925	Bourjois	Manon Lescaut face powder	Herald Tribune
Green Rouge!	1925	Bourjois	Manon Lescaut face powder	Pictorial Review
Beauty from Trees	1925	Palmolive Company	Soap	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
Nature's Gift to Beauty	1926	Palmolive Company	Palmolive Soap	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
"Daisy"	1927	Pixavon	Shampoo	Illustrirte Zeitung, Open Library of Humanities
In shops where trifles are treasures worth a king's ransom… you are told: "For extra-safety, use a soap mild enough for your skin"	1927	Procter & Gamble Co.	Ivory Soap	Delineator

(*continued*)

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Table A1. Continued

Title	Date	Company	Product	Source
Husbands… you may be Sorry!	1928	Wildroot Company, Inc.	Wildroot Hair Preparations	Gale Digital Collections
Nature's Chlorophyll is in every cake of Palmolive Soap	1928	Palmolive-Peet which acquired the Colgate Company	Soap	Tedium Archives
Chinese calendar poster advertisement for Pond's Vanishing Cream	1929	Ponds	Cream	MOFBA collection
Coty Culturiste Creations	1930	Coty, Inc.	Culturiste Creations	Online Books Page by the University of Pennsylvania
It's Almost Easier To Have A Lovely Skin Than Not By This Simple Du Barry Home Way	1930	Richard Hudnut	Du Barry Beauty Treatments	The Library of Congress
The Most Important Announcement Ever Made In The Science Of Skin Treatment	1930	Denney & Denney	Herbal Preparations	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
Bare Your Face To Sun And Wind	1931	Denney & Denney	Herbal Preparations	Town & Country
The Swift Pace Of Living… demands this special skin care	1931	Denney & Denney	Herbal Preparations	Vogue
Yardley's Orchis	1931	Yardley & Co., Ltd.	Orchis perfume	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
"Two Girls Brand"	1932	Kwong Sang Hong company	Cosmetics and toiletries	Cambridge University Press
Be as Modern as you like	1932	Denney & Denney	Herbal Preparations	Harper's Bazaar
If your husband were as frank as your mirror, would he say: 'Don't grow old, Dear…"	1932	Dorothy Gray	Dorothy Gray treatments	The National Archives
How the English Woman protects her soft, Gardenia skin	1933	Yardley & Co., Ltd.	English Lavender Cosmetics	Good Housekeeping
Olive oil is nature's great beautifier	1933	Colgate-Palmolive-Peet Company	Palmolive Soap	New York Sun
Breaking Into Society	1933	Lever Brothers Company	Lifebuoy Health Soap	Saturday Evening Post
English Complexion Cream that keeps an English skin like rose leaves	1934	Yardley & Co., Ltd.	English Lavender face powder and complexion cream	Woman's Home Companion

(*continued*)

Table A1. Continued

Title	Date	Company	Product	Source
For healthy hair, use Wildroot Hair Tonic instead of water	1934	Wildroot Company, Inc.	Wildroot Hair Tonic	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
Translucent Loveliness, Gift Of The Du Barry Beauty Preparations	1934	Richard Hudnut	Du Barry Beauty Preparations	Harper's Bazaar, Archives
High Noon in New York	1935	Dorothy Gray	Dorothy Gray Cosmetics	The National Archives
Lavender…Cool As Breezes Blowing Over Gardens By The Sea	1935	Yardley & Co., Ltd.	English Lavender	New York Herald Tribune
Pechoin Cosmetics	1935	Pechoin	Skin Care	Cambridge Core
Wind-Whipped Faces	1935	Richard Hudnut	Du Barry Beauty Preparations	Vogue Archives
"Two Girls" Talcum Powder	1936	Kwong Sang Hong	Talcum Powder	Goldthread
Age comes fast after 30	1936	Dorothy Gray	Dorothy Gray Cosmetics	Harper's Bazaar, Archives
"TWOSOME"…sensitive skin and pure Ivory agree!	1937	Procter & Gamble Co.	Ivory Soap	Saturday Evening Post
Drene Shampoo Ad "The Amazing Shampoo"	1937	Procter and Gamble	Shampoo	Life
Palm Oil, Olive Oil, Palmolive	1938	Palmolive Company	Soap	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
Sky Blue Pink	1939	Elizabeth Arden	Sky Blue Pink Color Harmony Box	Vogue
Frances Denney presents a romantic fragrance Wild Rose	1940	Frances Denney	Wild Rose fragrance and makeup	Harper's Bazaar, Archives
Nature's Aids to Loveliness	1940	Botany Distributors	Botany Lanolin Beauty Aids	Duke University Libraries Digital Collections
Pan-Cake Make-up and Tru-Color Lipstick featuring actress Joan Crawford	1940	Max Factor	Makeup	The Young Companion
Two experts… You and Charles of the Ritz	1940	Charles of the Ritz	Individually Color-Blended Face Powder	Vogue Archives
Quick White	1940s	Phoenix Brand	Soap	Chronicle Books
John Frederics Fashions A Bonnet Fresh as a Spring Bouquet	1941	Avon	Avon Cosmetics	Ad*Access, Duke Digital Collections
Make the most of your beauty! Find Your Type In This New Chart By Palmolive	1941	Palmolive Company	Palmolive Soap	Life Archives

(*continued*)

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Table A1. Continued

Title	Date	Company	Product	Source
New! for fresh, delicious, summer charm… Raspberry Ice	1941	Charles of the Ritz	Raspberry Ice Beauty Products	Ad*Access, Duke Digital Collections
Eternally Feminine This Captivating Spring Suit By Blotta	1942	Avon	Cosmetics	Northwestern University Archives
Marvellous Value!	1942	LUX	Soap	Woman's Own
One Best Beauty Soap	1942	Palmolive Company	Palmolive Soap	Cosmopolitan Archives
One beauty secret lovely women have cherished always Olive & Palm Oils	1942	Palmolive Company	Palmolive Soap	Ladies' Home Journal
Dusting Powder Eau De Cologne	1943	Germaine Monteil	Perfume	New Yorker Digital Archive
Fresh Paint To Keep You Summer-Lovely	1943	Helena Rubinstein	Helena Rubinstein make-up	Glamour
The Dahlias are marching through the garden	1943	Mary Dunhill	"Change-over" Treatment	Ad*Access, Duke Digital Collections
"Wonderful what Lavender does…!"	1944	Yardley of London, Inc.	English Lavender Cosmetics	McCall's
Abano	1944	Prince Matchabelli, Inc.	Abano Bath Oil	New Yorker Digital Archive
Think of Greece And you Think of Beauty	1944	Germaine Monteil	Cosmetics and toiletries	ProQuest
Coral Reef	1945	Germaine Monteil	Lipstick	New Yorker Digital Archive
For Easter..	1946	Charles of the Ritz	Moss Rose Cosmetics	Ad*Access, Duke Digital Collections
"Spring Spring Spring time to wake a sleepy skin"	1947	Dorothy Gray	Dorothy Gray Cosmetics	Good Housekeeping
fresh the whole day spring the whole year	1947	Germaine Monteil	Cosmetics	New Yorker Digital Archive
like Paris in the Spring	1947	Coty, Inc.	Cosmetics	Cosmopolitan Archives
"Bill's Dream Girl"	1948	Lustre-Creme	Shampoo	Vogue Archives
"Newest kind"	1948	Pond's Make-Up	Face powder	Vogue Archives
"oh-oh, Dry Scalp!"	1948	Vasline	Hair Tonic	Saturday Evening Post
The Couple who broke the rules! No "Skin-Burn" with Woodbury's Beauty-Cream Ingredient!	1949	Woodbury	Facial Soap	Life Archives
"Revolutionary New Deodorant Powder Gives Fragrant All-Over Body Protection!"	1950	SHAKTI	Deodorant Powder	Good Housekeeping
AIRSPUN	1950	Coty, Inc.	Cosmetics	The Women's Weekly

(*continued*)

Table A1. Continued

Title	Date	Company	Product	Source
Beauty is my business	1950	SweetHeart	SweetHeart Toilet Soap	Screen Stories
Elizabeth Arden Hand Lotion	1950	Elizabeth Arden	Hand Lotion	Harper's Bazaar
Just as a couturier designs my suits, a milliner my hats, a furrier my furs… my face powder is made to order!	1950	Charles of the Ritz	Hand-Blended Powder	Vogue Archives
Reckitt's Bathjoys	1950	Reckitt's	Floral bath cubes	Woman's Own
Sky High	1950	Grossmith Sky High	Perfume	The Illustrated London News
Only THIS shampoo… contains fresh Whole egg… that leaves hair so-o soft yet easy to manage!!	1950	Helene Curtis Industries Incorporated	Shampoo with natural egg	New York News
Fresh from the English countryside	1951	Yardley of London, Inc.	English Lavender Cosmetics	Good Housekeeping
Now! The Colgate-Palmolive-Peet Company Announces "Nature's Chlorophyll"	1952	Colgate-Palmolive-Peet Company	Palmolive Soap	American Weekly
Tangee Lipstick	1952	Tangee	Lipstick	Picture Post Historical Archive
Cussons Talcum Powders	1954	Cussons	Talcum Powders	ProQuest
For the freshest, youngest feeling in the world	1954	Yardley of London, Inc.	Lavender Bath Oil	Life Archives
Ponds Creams	1955	Ponds	Creams	Mademoiselle
"2,000 fragrant red rose petals"	1961	Yardley	Perfume	Harper's Bazaar, Archives
"The Soft Look"	1962	Max Factor	Eye makeup	Life Archives
Max Factor Haute Colour.	1965	Max Factor	Makeup	Harper's Bazaar, Archives
"The closer he gets"	1966	Clairol Hair Color Ad	Hair Color	Life and Ladies' Home Journal
Softie Gala Lipstick	1966	GALA	Lipstick	Seventeen
Wella Hair Cream Rinses	1970	Wella	Hair cream	Cosmopolitan Archives
Wella Creme Rinse	1971	Wella	Creme Rinse for Hair	Elle
Clinique	1977	Clinique	Face cream	HAT Image Gallery
Opium perfume	1977	Yves Saint Laurent	Perfume	Vogue Archives

Source(s): Authors' own work

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